like nightmares. ‘The thought of death took hold of everyone,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl as thousands of Mughal troops and villagers died of disease. ‘Things came to such a pass that the living were unable to bury the dead,’ agreed Badauni, ‘and threw them head foremost into the river.’ The elderly warlord Munim Khan died, too, undone, in the end, not by any flashing sword or betraying clansman but by the plague, noxious and invisible. According to historian Eaton, this catastrophic plague occurring right at the beginning of Mughal inroads into Bengal, ‘contributed to the stereotype, soon accepted throughout the imperial service, that Bengal was a hostile and foreign land’.

As the Mughal women prepared to board the great hajj ships, the *Salimi* and the *Ilahi*, either built or bought by Akbar in the three years since Gujarat was taken, Akbar sent Khan Jahan and Raja Todar Mal to Bengal, to deal with Daud Khan who, with Munim Khan now dead, was once again flirting with the idea of rebellion. In the lavish rain of the monsoon of 1576, Daud Khan Afghan was finally defeated. His horse got trapped in the sliding mud and he was captured. Apparently, Khan Jahan hesitated to behead him as per imperial orders ‘for he was a very handsome man’. The deed was done, however, and his head, stuffed and perfumed, was sent to the emperor while his trunk was gibbeted at Tanda.

Once in the Holy Lands, the Mughal ladies, having travelled far away from the gaunt topography of their lives at Fatehpur Sikri, were determined to participate fully in all that this great occasion had to offer. These widows and daughters of Babur could reclaim those earlier, less constrained, times when they had wandered in the wake of their peripatetic husbands and brothers across the country. In the next few years, the women would participate in the communal aspect of the hajj and would distribute the extravagant wealth that Akbar had provided for the occasion—six lakh rupees and many robes of honour as gifts. This wealth was so ostentatious that it would cause a sharp reaction from the Ottoman authorities. Between 1578 and 1580 five documents were sent from Sultan Murad III, the Ottoman sultan, to the authorities at Mecca, complaining about the extended stay of the Mughal ladies and the ‘anti-Sharia’ activities indulged in by them. They railed against the overcrowding of the Holy Cities due to the enormous retinues of the ladies and the large number of pilgrims attracted by their largesse. The sultan further gave instructions to the Sharif of Mecca to encourage them to leave the Holy Lands as soon as they had completed the pilgrimages and even prohibited the distribution of the alms